Common Indian City Birds

Beginner field guide: real photographs + schematic identification markers + simple bird-family context.
Designed for low-ink A4 printing.

How to identify a bird in 20 seconds

1. Where is it?
Water, lawn, tree canopy, wire, rooftop, or high in the sky?

2. Size
Sparrow, myna, pigeon, crow, or kite-sized? Size narrows the options quickly.

3. Shape
Notice bill length/curve, leg length, body posture, wing shape and tail shape.

4. Strongest mark
Eye stripe, wing patch, crest, red vent, neck ring, forked tail, white throat, etc.

5. Behaviour
Walking, hovering, plunge-diving, tail-flicking, soaring, probing flowers, or hawking insects?

6. Call
Once the visual ID is close, the call often confirms it. Do not rely on colour alone.

Think in habitats first

Water & banks	Lawns & roads	Shrubs & gardens	Wires & open plots	Sky & tall trees
egrets, pond heron, kingfishers	mynas, pigeons, sparrows	robins, bulbuls, sunbirds, tailorbird	bee-eater, drongo, kingfisher	kites, Shikra, eagle

Useful Hindi bird words

Hindi names vary by region. Treat them as helpful local vocabulary; use the English + scientific name when you need an exact species.

English / group	Hindi	Useful note
Waterbirds	जलपक्षी *jalpakshi*	A practical umbrella term, not one scientific family.
Heron / egret	बगुला / बगला *bagula / bagla*	Many individual species have more specific regional names.
Kingfisher	किलकिला / राम चिरैया	Names vary by species and region.
Bee-eater	पतरिंगा *patringa*	Commonly used for the Green Bee-eater.
Sunbird	शकरखोरा / फूल सूंघनी	Older bird literature uses these nectar-feeder names.
Kite	चील *cheel*	In Indian cities this very often means Black Kite.
Eagle	उकाब *ukab*	*Garud* is broader/literary; not a precise field identification term.
Vulture	गिद्ध *giddh*	Large soaring scavenger; not simply a “big eagle”.
Myna / Koel / Bulbul	मैना / कोयल / बुलबुल	These everyday names are already close to the English names.

Vernacular examples are cross-checked against BNHS/EIACP vernacular-name resources and Indian government bird guides. Local usage still varies.

Bird groups at a glance

Learn the silhouette and feeding style first; species identification becomes much easier.

Waterbirds

जलपक्षी

Birds tied to lakes, rivers, marshes and shores. This includes many unrelated families: herons, egrets, storks, cormorants, kingfishers, ducks and more.

Clue: bill + leg shape usually tells you how they feed.

Herons & egrets

बगुला / बगला

Long legs, spear-like bill and an S-shaped neck. Egrets are essentially white herons.

Flight clue: the neck is usually folded back, not stretched straight forward.

Storks

स्टॉर्क; traditional local names vary

Large, long-legged waders with heavier bills. They often soar and may feed by probing or snapping at aquatic prey.

Flight clue: neck extended straight. Do not confuse “Sarus” (a crane) with a stork.

Kingfishers

किलकिला / राम चिरैया

Big head, strong bill, compact body. Many watch from a perch and pounce.

Surprise: White-throated Kingfisher often eats lizards and insects away from water.

Bee-eaters

पतरिंगा

Slender, colourful aerial insect hunters with slightly curved bills. They sit on wires and make short flights after bees, wasps and dragonflies.

Clue: return repeatedly to the same perch.

Sunbirds

शकरखोरा

Tiny nectar feeders with slender curved bills. They also eat insects, especially when feeding young.

Clue: rapid movement around flowers; usually perch rather than hover continuously.

Raptors / शिकारी पक्षी: kite vs eagle vs Shikra/hawk vs vulture

	Kite - चील	Eagle - उकाब	Shikra / hawk - शिकरा	Vulture - गिद्ध
Build	Slender, long-winged	Heavier, powerful	Compact, agile	Large, broad-winged
Tail	Often long; Black Kite shallow fork	Usually broader / less forked	Long tail, useful for steering	Usually short to moderate
Flight	Easy circling, buoyant glides	Strong soaring, broad wings	Fast bursts through trees	Long effortless soaring on thermals
Food	Scavenging + small prey	Mostly active predation	Small birds, lizards, rodents	Mostly carrion
City clue	Black Kite is very common overhead	Less routinely urban	Can appear suddenly in leafy streets	Now uncommon in many cities; several Indian species are threatened

Remember: “large bird circling” does not automatically mean eagle. Tail shape, wing proportions and behaviour are more reliable than size alone.

Common Indian City Birds - Photo + Field Marks

Four birds per page. Genuine photographs, schematic ID markers, food, habits and where to look. Includes mynas, bulbuls, koel, bee-eater, sunbirds, kingfishers, egrets, kites, Shikra and eagle.

Common Myna

Medium

Acridotheres tristis

मैना



ID MARKER SKETCH



- black hood
- yellow eye patch + bill
- white wing flash

Photo: Shino jacob koottanad | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Brown body, black hood, bright yellow bill and eye patch, with obvious white wing patches in flight.

Food: Insects, fruit, scraps and almost any available urban food.

Habits: Bold, noisy and adaptable; walks confidently on lawns and roads and often roosts communally.

Look for: Parks, markets, rooftops, lawns and roadside trees.

Jungle Myna

Medium

Acridotheres fuscus

मैना



ID MARKER SKETCH



- small forehead tuft
- grey-brown body
- pale bluish eye skin

Photo: Vijay Barve | CC BY 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Greyer-brown than Common Myna, with a small forehead tuft and pale bluish skin behind the eye; bill yellow-orange.

Food: Insects, fruit, seeds and human food scraps.

Habits: Feeds on the ground and around grazing animals; often mixes with other mynas.

Look for: Open lawns, campuses, fields, roadside verges and wet areas.

Oriental Magpie-Robin

Small-medium

Copsychus saularis



ID MARKER SKETCH



- black/grey + white
- bold white wing bar
- long often-cocked tail

Photo: Nicholas Iyadurai | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Male glossy black-and-white; female grey-and-white. Long tail often held cocked; white wing bar is prominent.

Food: Insects and other small invertebrates; some fruit.

Habits: Active ground-and-low-perch hunter; males sing rich varied phrases from exposed perches.

Look for: Gardens, compounds, parks, shaded lanes and low walls.

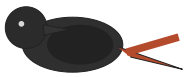
Indian Robin

Small

Copsychus fulicatus



ID MARKER SKETCH



- white shoulder patch
- chestnut undertail
- tail frequently cocked

Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Male mostly dark with a clear white shoulder patch and chestnut undertail; female browner with chestnut undertail.

Food: Insects, spiders and other small invertebrates.

Habits: Frequently flicks or cocks the tail; hunts from rocks, walls and low perches.

Look for: Dry gardens, walls, scrub, vacant plots and rocky urban edges.

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Red-vented Bulbul

Small-medium

Pycnonotus cafer

बुलबुल



ID MARKER SKETCH



- black pointed crest
- red vent
- pale tail tip

Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Dark crested head, brown scaly-looking body, black tail with pale tip and a vivid red patch under the tail.

Food: Fruit, berries, nectar and insects.

Habits: Pairs or small groups; lively and vocal, often visiting flowering and fruiting garden plants.

Look for: Gardens, hedges, balconies, parks and roadside trees.

Red-whiskered Bulbul

Small-medium

Pycnonotus jocosus

बुलबुल



ID MARKER SKETCH



- tall black crest
- red cheek patch
- red vent

Photo: PJeganathan | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Tall black crest, white cheek with red whisker patch, white underparts and red vent.

Food: Fruit, nectar and insects.

Habits: Perches openly, gives ringing calls and travels in pairs or small groups.

Look for: Leafy gardens, parks, campuses and wooded residential areas.

Purple Sunbird

Tiny

Cinnyris asiaticus



ID MARKER SKETCH



- tiny curved bill
- male glossy purple-black
- female olive-yellow

Photo: K. Hari Krishnan | CC BY-SA 3.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Breeding male appears glossy purple-black in good light; female olive above and yellow below with a slender curved bill.

Food: Nectar plus small insects and spiders.

Habits: Rapid, restless feeder; probes flowers and may hover briefly but usually perches to feed.

Look for: Flowering gardens, balconies, parks and ornamental shrubs.

Purple-rumped Sunbird

Tiny

Leptocoma zeylonica



ID MARKER SKETCH



- bright yellow belly
- purple crown/rump
- maroon upperparts

Photo: Sumita Roy Dutta | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Male has maroon upperparts, metallic purple crown/rump and bright yellow belly; female olive above and yellow below.

Food: Nectar, tiny insects and spiders.

Habits: Very active around blossoms; often gives sharp calls while moving through foliage.

Look for: Flower-rich gardens, residential trees and parks in peninsular India.

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Green Bee-eater

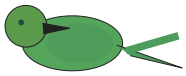
Small

Merops orientalis

पतरिंगा



ID MARKER SKETCH



- bright green
- black eye-stripe
- two long central tail feathers

Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Slender bright green bird with black eye-stripe, thin downcurved bill and elongated central tail feathers on adults.

Food: Flying insects, especially bees, wasps, dragonflies and flies.

Habits: Makes short aerial sallies from wires or bare twigs, then returns to the same perch; beats stinging prey before swallowing.

Look for: Wires, fences, open plots, lakesides and sunny scrub.

Rose-ringed Parakeet

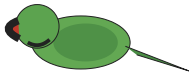
Medium

Psittacula krameri

तोता



ID MARKER SKETCH



- long pointed tail
- red bill
- male neck ring

Photo: PJeganathan | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Long-tailed bright green parakeet with red bill; adult male has a black-and-rose neck ring.

Food: Seeds, fruit, buds, flowers and cultivated crops.

Habits: Fast direct flight with loud calls; social, often commuting between feeding and communal roost sites.

Look for: Large avenue trees, parks, gardens and fruiting trees.

Asian Koel

Large cuckoo

Eudynamys scolopaceus

कोयल



ID MARKER SKETCH



- male glossy black + red eye
- female brown, white-spotted
- long tail

Photo: Anton Croos | CC BY-SA 3.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Male glossy black with red eye; female brown with heavy white spotting and streaking. Long tail in both sexes.

Food: Mostly fruit and berries; also insects and other foods.

Habits: Often hidden in foliage but unmistakably vocal in the breeding season; lays eggs in crow nests.

Look for: Dense fruiting trees, large gardens and old residential avenues.

Black Drongo

Medium

Dicrurus macrocercus

कोतवाल / भुजंगा



ID MARKER SKETCH



- all black
- deeply forked tail
- upright exposed perch

Photo: Raman Kumar | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Entirely glossy black with a strongly forked tail; upright stance on exposed perches.

Food: Flying insects and other small prey.

Habits: Bold aerial insect hunter; aggressively chases crows and raptors much larger than itself.

Look for: Wires, poles, open lawns, fields and city fringes.

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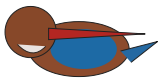
White-throated Kingfisher

Medium-large

Halcyon smyrnensis



ID MARKER SKETCH



- white throat/breast
- bright blue wings/back
- large red bill

Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Chocolate-brown head and body, brilliant blue back and wings, large red bill and a clean white throat/breast patch.

Food: Insects, lizards, frogs, small fish, crabs and even small rodents.

Habits: Often hunts away from water, dropping from a prominent perch onto prey.

Look for: Wires, poles, rooftops, parks, open ground and lakesides.

Common Kingfisher

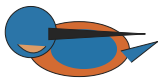
Small

Alcedo atthis

राम चिरैया / छोटा किलकिला



ID MARKER SKETCH



- electric blue upperparts
- orange underparts
- long dagger bill

Photo: Shantanu Kuveskar | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Compact electric-blue and orange kingfisher with long pointed dark bill and very short tail.

Food: Small fish, tadpoles and aquatic insects.

Habits: Perches low over water, watches intently, then dives steeply to catch prey.

Look for: Clean ponds, canals, lakes, streams and quiet urban wetlands.

Cattle Egret

Medium heron

Bubulcus ibis

गाय बगुला



ID MARKER SKETCH



- compact white egret
- yellow bill
- often follows cattle

Photo: Raman Kumar | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Stocky white egret with short thick yellow bill; breeding birds develop orange-buff head, breast and back.

Food: Grasshoppers and other insects; also frogs and small vertebrates.

Habits: Often follows cattle, lawn mowers or tractors to catch disturbed prey; commonly feeds well away from water.

Look for: Lawns, sports grounds, roadside grass, fields and wetland edges.

Little Egret

Medium heron

Egretta garzetta

छोटा बगुला



ID MARKER SKETCH



- slender white egret
- black bill + black legs
- bright yellow feet

Photo: PJeganathan | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Slim all-white egret with black bill, black legs and contrasting yellow feet.

Food: Small fish, frogs, insects and crustaceans.

Habits: Active feeder that walks, runs and stirs shallow water with its feet to flush prey.

Look for: Lake edges, drains, marshes, canals and shallow urban water bodies.

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Indian Pond Heron

Medium heron

Ardeola grayii

बगुला / बगला



ID MARKER SKETCH



- brown at rest
- white wings flash in flight
- yellowish bill

Photo: Vivek Puliyeri | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: At rest looks streaky brown and cryptic; in flight suddenly shows broad gleaming white wings.

Food: Fish, frogs, tadpoles, insects and crustaceans.

Habits: Stands hunched and still at the water edge, then strikes quickly; surprisingly tame in cities.

Look for: Ponds, storm drains, lake margins, canals and wet lawns.

Rock Pigeon

Medium

Columba livia

कबूतर



ID MARKER SKETCH



- grey body
- two dark wing bars
- iridescent neck

Photo: Muhammad Mahdi Karim Facebook The making of this document was supported by Wi…

ID: Typical bird has blue-grey body, two black wing bars, dark tail band and iridescent neck, but city colours vary widely.

Food: Seeds, grain and human food scraps.

Habits: Highly social; nests on building ledges that mimic natural cliffs and gathers in large feeding flocks.

Look for: Buildings, stations, markets, bridges and open squares.

Spotted Dove

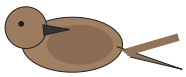
Medium

Spilopelia chinensis

फाख्ता



ID MARKER SKETCH



- spotted black neck patch
- warm brown body
- long tail

Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Warm brown dove with long tail and a black hind-neck patch covered in fine white spots.

Food: Seeds and small grains taken mostly from the ground.

Habits: Usually seen in pairs; walks quietly on the ground and gives a soft repeated cooing call.

Look for: Gardens, quiet streets, campuses, scrubby lots and parks.

House Crow

Medium-large

Corvus splendens

कौआ



ID MARKER SKETCH



- black head/wings
- grey neck + breast
- slender crow build

Photo: Lip Kee Yap | CC BY-SA 2.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Black face, wings and tail with contrasting grey neck and breast; slimmer than many other crows.

Food: Omnivorous: scraps, fruit, insects, eggs and almost anything edible.

Habits: Highly intelligent, social and opportunistic; commonly gathers at food sources and communal roosts.

Look for: Almost any urban habitat, especially markets, streets and waterfronts.

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House Sparrow

Small

Passer domesticus

गौरैया



ID MARKER SKETCH



male black bib

chestnut + grey head

female plain sandy-brown

Photo: Dr. Raju Kasambe | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Male has grey crown, chestnut nape and black bib; female is plain sandy-brown with a pale eyebrow.

Food: Seeds and grain; chicks receive many insects.

Habits: Social and closely associated with people; nests in holes and cavities in buildings.

Look for: Older neighbourhoods, shops, markets, gardens and buildings with nesting crevices.

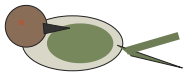
Common Tailorbird

Tiny

Orthotomus sutorius



ID MARKER SKETCH



rusty crown

olive back

long often-cocked tail

Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Small olive bird with whitish underparts, rusty crown and a long often-cocked tail; breeding males have elongated central tail feathers.

Food: Tiny insects, caterpillars and spiders.

Habits: Skulks actively through shrubs; famously stitches leaves together with plant fibre to form its nest.

Look for: Dense hedges, balcony plants, gardens and low shrubs.

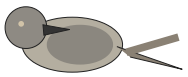
Ashy Prinia

Tiny

Prinia socialis



ID MARKER SKETCH



grey-brown

very long graduated tail

tail often upright

Photo: Shantanu Kuveskar | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Small grey-brown warbler with long graduated tail often held upright; underparts pale and flanks buffy.

Food: Small insects and spiders.

Habits: Restless low-level forager with a distinctive repetitive call; tail flicks frequently.

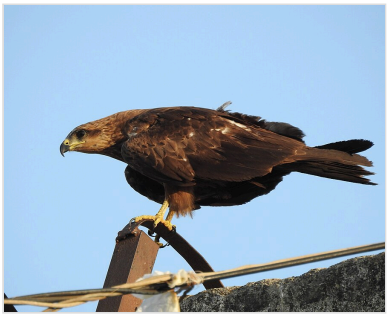
Look for: Shrubby gardens, hedges, grassy plots and scrubby city edges.

Black Kite

Large raptor

Milvus migrans

चील



ID MARKER SKETCH



shallow forked tail

long angled wings

dark brown soaring raptor

Photo: Dr. Raju Kasambe | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Dark brown raptor with long wings and a shallowly forked tail; often seen circling and gliding over cities.

Food: Carrion, scraps, fish, rodents and other small animals.

Habits: Expert scavenger and soaring flier; may gather in numbers around markets, dumps and evening roosts.

Look for: Sky over dense neighbourhoods, markets, rivers and tall nesting trees.

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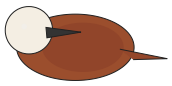
Brahminy Kite

Large raptor

Haliastur indus



ID MARKER SKETCH



- white head + breast
- rich chestnut body
- broad rounded wings

Photo: Afsarnayakkan | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Adult is rich chestnut with a striking white head and breast; broad rounded wings and short tail.

Food: Fish, crabs, carrion and small animals.

Habits: Soars and patrols shorelines and wetlands, taking prey from the surface or scavenging.

Look for: Cities near lakes, rivers, coasts and large wetlands.

Shikra

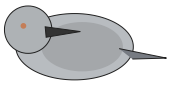
Small raptor

Accipiter badius

शिकरा



ID MARKER SKETCH



- short rounded wings
- long barred tail
- adult male grey + orange barring

Photo: Varun Omanakuttan | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Compact hawk with short rounded wings and long barred tail; adult male grey above with orange-barred underparts and red eye.

Food: Small birds, lizards, rodents and large insects.

Habits: Fast ambush hunter that darts through trees and around buildings; often perches quietly inside foliage.

Look for: Tree-lined streets, gardens, campuses and city parks.

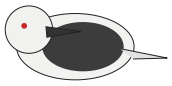
Black-winged Kite

Small-medium raptor

Elanus caeruleus



ID MARKER SKETCH



- very pale body
- black shoulder patches
- red eyes; often hovers

Photo: Kingshuk Mondal | CC BY 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Pale grey-white raptor with black shoulder patches and bright red eyes; pointed wings and buoyant flight.

Food: Mostly small rodents, plus lizards and large insects.

Habits: Frequently hovers in place before dropping on prey; prefers open ground with scattered perches.

Look for: City outskirts, vacant fields, grasslands, highway verges and open campuses.

Booted Eagle

Medium eagle

Hieraaetus pennatus



ID MARKER SKETCH



- broader eagle wings
- compact but powerful build
- feathered legs

Photo: Dr. Raju Kasambe | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID: Compact eagle with feathered legs; light morph has pale underparts with dark flight feathers, while dark morph is mostly brown.

Food: Small birds, reptiles and mammals.

Habits: Soars on broad wings and hunts with fast stoops; a seasonal winter visitor in many parts of India.

Look for: High over parks, wooded campuses, reservoirs and open urban edges in cooler months.